The second lot would reach the road between the langar complex and Guru Nanak Niwas in bulletproof vehicles, take charge of the captured Bhindranwale from the heliborne commandos and whisk him away to a predetermined place, where he would be handed over to the authorities concerned.

The heliborne and ground-based SFF commandos were specifically instructed that Bhindranwale should in no case be allowed to go towards the Harmandir Sahib sanctum to take refuge, as capturing him from there without causing damage to the building would not be possible and causing damage to the main Harmandir Sahib structure was unacceptable.

According to Nagrani, the Golden Temple complex model used to plan the operation, along with the SFF personnel being trained, was shifted to the National Capital Region of Delhi towards the end of March 1984 to facilitate closer cooperation with the CRPF. Nagrani distinctly recalled the visit of the advisor from SAS. He specifically mentioned that the advice given by the advisor was meant exclusively for the SFF heliborne operation and not for the army-led Operation Blue Star, which was not even at the planning stage at the time. He, however, mentioned that as it turned out, his SFF commandos were later requisitioned by Lt Gen. K. Sundarji for Operation Blue Star at short notice.

Briefing Indira Gandhi

In early April 1984, R.N. Kao told Nagrani that Indira Gandhi wanted a briefing on the heliborne operation at 1 Akbar Road, at her private office wing adjoining her residence, 1 Safdarjung Road. Nagrani was initially hesitant and did not want to brief her. He therefore requested Kao to brief the PM personally, since Kao was also fully conversant with the details of the operation. Ultimately however, Nagrani relented and briefed her in Kao's presence. After the briefing, the PM pointedly asked Nagrani about the number of casualties that could be expected. Nagrani said he could lose both the helicopters and about 20 per cent of the commandos.

Indira Gandhi then specifically asked him about the possibility of civilian casualties. Nagrani had no answer to that. The operation